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Facultad Regional Córdoba

TUP

Tecnicatura Universitaria en Programación

INGLÉS I

Unidad Temática N° 1:
Frase Nominal

Actividad Complementaria II
1° Año – 2° Cuatrimestre

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Types of Computer Systems

A - From mainframes to wearable computers

A **mainframe** is the most powerful type of computer. It can process and store large amounts of data. It supports multiple users at the same time and can support more simultaneous processes than a PC. The central system is a large server connected to hundreds of terminals over a network. Mainframes are used for large-scale computing purposes in banks, big companies and universities.

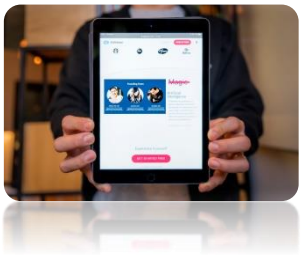
A **desktop PC** has its own processing unit (or CPU), monitor and keyboard. It is used as a personal computer in the home or as a workstation for group work. Typical examples are the IBM PC and the Apple Macintosh. It's designed to be placed on your desk. Some models have a vertical case called a tower.

A **laptop** (also called a **notebook PC**) is a lightweight computer that you can transport easily. It can work as fast as a desktop PC, with similar processors, memory capacity, and disk drives, but it is portable and has a smaller screen. Modern notebooks have a **TFT (Thin Film Transistor)** screen that produces very sharp images.

Instead of a mouse, they have a **touchpad** built into the keyboard – a sensitive pad that you can touch to move the pointer on the screen.

They offer a lot of connectivity options: **USB (Universal Serial Bus) ports** for connecting peripherals, slots for memory cards, etc.

They come with **battery packs**, which let you use the computer when there are no electrical outlets available.



A **tablet PC** looks like a book, with an LCD screen on which you can write using a special digital pen. You can fold and rotate the screen 180 degrees. Your handwriting can be recognized and converted into editable text. You can also type at the detached keyboard or use voice recognition. It's mobile and versatile.

A **personal digital assistant** or **PDA** is a tiny computer which can be held in one hand. The term PDA refers to a wide variety of **hand-held** devices, palmtops and pocket PCs.

For input, you type at a small keyboard or use a **stylus** - a special pen used with a **touch screen** to select items, draw pictures, etc. Some models incorporate **handwriting recognition**, which enables a PDA to recognize characters written by hand. Some PDAs recognize spoken words by using **voice recognition** software.

They can be used as mobile phones or as personal organizers for storing notes, reminders and addresses. They also let you access the Internet via **wireless** technology, without cables.

A **wearable computer** runs on batteries and is worn on the user's body, e.g. on a belt, backpack or vest; it is designed for mobile or hands-free operation. Some devices are equipped with a wireless modem, a small keyboard and a screen; others are voice-activated and can access email or voice mail.

1. **Look at section A above. Which type of computer do these descriptions refer to?**

1- a hand-held computer which can be used as a telephone, a web explorer and a personal
organizer _____

2- a typical computer found in many businesses and popular for home use _____

3- a large computer used for intensive data processing and often linked to many terminals _____

4- a small computer that fits into items of clothing _____

5- a portable computer that can be closed up like a briefcase, but it can be as powerful as a desktop PC _____

6- a full-function PC, though it only weighs 1.2 kg – you can go to a meeting and write your notes on it, like a paper notepad; its screen mode can be changed from portrait to landscape _____

2. Look at the computer advertisement below and find this information.

1- What type of computer is advertised?

2- What kind of screen does it have?

3- Which pointing device replaces the mouse?

4- What type of ports does it have for connecting cameras and music players?

5- What sort of power supply does it use?

Toshiba Satellite

- Intel Centrino processor
- 1,024 MB RAM, 100 GB hard disk drive
- DVD SuperMulti (+/-R double layer) drive
- 15.4" Widescreen TFT active-matrix LCD display
- 85-key keyboard and touchpad
- 2 memory slots, 1 Pc Card or PCMCIA slot
- Wireless communications: Wi-Fi compliancy and Bluetooth
- 4 USB ports for connecting peripherals: digital camera, MP3 player, modem, etc.
- 6-cell rechargeable Lithium-ion battery pack

3. Read this interview with Adam Hawkins, an IT manager, and complete it with words from the PDA section above.

Interviewer: What are the basic features of a PDA?

Adam: Well, a typical PDA is a (1) _____ device that runs on batteries and combines computing, phone and Net capabilities.

Interviewer: And how do you enter information?

Adam: For input, you use a (2) _____ or pen to write and make selections on a (3) _____ _____; they also have buttons for launching programs. Some models have a small keyboard. They may have a (4) _____ _____ system that reacts to the user's voice.

Interviewer: Do they need special software?

Adam: Yes, most of them run on *Windows Mobile*. Palmtops supported by Palm Inc. use *Palm OS*. Pen-based systems include (5) _____, so you write on the screen and the computer recognizes your handwriting and inserts the appropriate letters.

Interviewer: What sort of things can you do with a PDA?

Adam: You can store personal information, take notes, draw diagrams and make calculations. Many PDAs can access the Net via (6) _____ technology.

Bibliografía

Marco Fabré, E. & S. Remacha Esteras. (2007). *Professional English in Use ICT* (Intermediate to Advanced). Cambridge, UK. Cambridge University Press.

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